

To a National Spiritual Assembly

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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321 58 9 October 2015 To a National Spiritual Assembly Dear Bahá'í Friends, 58.1 . . . As you know, technological advancement is integral to

the emergence of a global civilization. Indeed, the Internet is a manifestation of a development anticipated by the Guardian when, in describing the characteristics of a unified humanity, he foresaw that a “mechanism of world intercommunication will be devised, embracing the whole planet, freed from national hindrances and restrictions, and functioning with marvelous swiftness and perfect regularity.” Yet, learning to utilize the Internet in a manner conducive to material and spiritual prog-ress is an immense challenge. 58.2 The Internet makes it possible for Bahá'í and Bahá'í-

inspired content to become accessible to a wide audience.

In this connection, the House of Justice has encouraged the strengthening of the official Bahá'í presence on the World Wide Web, and it has been pleased to see the many advances made, especially in recent years, and looks forward to the further unfoldment of this process. Beyond that, many believers around the world, each according to his or her circumstances and in coherence with other endeavors of the community, use the Internet as a medium for promoting Bahá'u'lláh's vision of a new World Order, and it is natural for the friends to explore different ways to do so. However, given that the Internet allows for the instantaneous dissemination of content among growing multitudes, wisdom and self-discipline are required lest the significance or dignity of the Teachings become compromised by an unbecoming, inaccurate, or trivialized presentation.

58.3 A related consideration is that the institutions of the Faith

are charged with the responsibility for creating and maintaining official sources of information about the Faith, such as national and international websites, regularly assessing the presentation 322 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION of the Faith on the World Wide Web and providing the neces- sary guidance to individuals. The friends are generally free to determine what aspects of the Teachings they wish to touch upon in their contributions but in doing so should clearly distinguish their sites from those created by the institutions.

This can be accomplished through a variety of means, including the name, description, or design of a site. While in the past the friends have at times been encouraged to refrain from using the word “Bahá'í,” or forms of it, in the name of their websites, experience has demonstrated that this may not always be necessary if other aspects of the site unmistakably identify it as an individual initiative. In addition, individuals will no doubt wish to avoid a tone that could be perceived as authoritative or instructional. They will also want to steer away from areas that lie exclusively within the sphere of institutional responsibility, such as offering a comprehensive collection of the writings and of the messages of the House of Justice or an exhaustive calendar of Bahá'í events across many countries. This becomes particularly significant when the visibility of a website increas- es and it gains prominence. As the institutions guide the friends in adopting the proper posture, the aim is not to unduly restrict their efforts but to avoid confusion and misinformation.

58.4 Notwithstanding that a site may, of course, be accessed

from any part of the world, a Bahá'í who seeks to establish a personal site should determine what would be an appropriate audience to address and the scope of subjects to be covered.

For example, while it may be beneficial to reflect on the nature and form of the core activities, especially in the context of the experience of a cluster or region, certain problems arise in attempting to create a site that aims to speak to Bahá'ís worldwide about the subject. Such an approach could lead to the cultural norms and values of a particular population being promoted to a universal audience—a pattern all too prevalent in the world today. There is also the danger of exerting an unintended influence on the process of learning unfolding at the grass roots, where individuals, communities, and institutions are acting as protagonists of their own growth and development. The perspectives offered in the following extract from the message dated 12 December 2011 from the House of Justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies—although in the specific context of artistic endeavors and supplementary 323

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]